

Half steps

A half step is the musical term for the interval or gap between notes that are immediately next to each other on the keyboard.

What are half steps?

A half step means “half a whole step” and represents a half step on the keyboard. If a note moves up a half step on the keyboard, it moves to the note immediately above it. Depending on the starting note, the note one half step above could be a black key or a white key.

SEE ALSO

◀ 48–51 Sharps and flats

Whole steps

54–55 ▶

Major scales

60–61 ▶

▽ Half step

Below are some examples of half steps— involving only white keys (E to F), a white key moving to a black key (A to B $\flat$) on the keyboard, and a black key moving to a white key (D $\flat$ to D).



△ On the staff

This is how the three half steps shown on the keyboard are written on the staff.